

task_sheet

Self-Serve Analytics — things to try

Thank you for doing this. It takes about **20 minutes**: work through the steps below one at a time, notice the things marked ☒, and fill in a short form once you have finished.

I am testing the tool, not you. If a step is confusing, that is exactly what I need to find out.

The tool is here: <https://self-serve-analytics.streamlit.app>

You have also been sent two data files — `orders.csv` and `order_items.csv`.

⚠ **Do not open `order_items.csv` until step 6.** The order matters.

What you are about to use

Self-Serve Analytics is a prototype for people who need answers out of their own data but do not write SQL — and who may never have used something like Power BI or Tableau either. You may know exactly what you want to find out, without knowing how to make the data give it to you.

You upload a spreadsheet, and the tool takes it from there. It points out anything that looks wrong with the data and asks whether you want it dealt with. It works out for itself what each column probably is — which one identifies a customer, which one is a date, which one holds an amount — and you can correct it where it has guessed wrong.

From that, it decides which standard analyses your data can support and makes those available to you. Anything it cannot run yet stays locked, with a note saying what is missing rather than the option quietly disappearing. Add another file later and more of them open up.

Every result comes with the SQL query behind it, so you can always see where a number came from. And there is a page where you can simply type a question in ordinary language.

None of this has to make complete sense yet — the steps below walk you through it.

1 • Get in

Open the link and create an account. It is a student prototype, so please use a throwaway password rather than one you use elsewhere.

2 • Start a project

Create a project and give it any name you like.

3 • Upload the first file

Upload **orders.csv**.

☒ **Notice:** how many rows and columns it found, and the preview of the data.

4 • Decide about data quality

The tool will show you what it thinks is wrong with the data, and ask whether you want it cleaned. Read what it found, then **decide for yourself** — clean it or leave it. Either choice is fine.

☒ **Notice:** whether you understood what it was offering to change, and whether you felt it was your decision or the tool's.

5 • Check what it made of your columns

The tool has already worked out what it thinks each column is. Go through them, and change anything it has got wrong.

☒ **Notice:** whether you could tell if it had guessed right, and whether the options on offer made sense to you.

6 • Open the Dashboard — and pause here

Go to the **Dashboard**. Do not skip past this screen.

☒ **Notice, and take a moment over it:** - Which analyses can you run right now? - Is

anything greyed out or unavailable? - If something is unavailable, does the tool tell you *why*? Does that reason make sense to you?

This screen is the heart of the study. Whatever you think of it — clear or baffling — is worth more to me than anything else on this sheet.

7 • Now add the second file

Now open `order_items.csv` and upload it into the same project.

Check what the tool made of this file too — including **how it thinks the two files relate to each other**, in other words how it can tell which rows belong together. Change anything that looks wrong.

☒ **Notice:** whether you could tell what it had decided about the two files, and whether you would have known how to fix it if it had been wrong.

8 • Go back to the Dashboard

☒ **Notice:** what has changed since step 6 — and whether you can explain to yourself why it changed.

9 • Answer a question with the dashboard

Using only the dashboard, work out **which product category sells the most**. Then narrow the view to the top 3.

10 • Look behind the numbers

Open the **SQL** behind one of the analyses — the query the tool wrote for you.

☒ **Notice:** whether seeing it makes you trust the number more, less, or neither.

Then download one of the results as a CSV.

11 • Ask in plain language

Go to the **Ask** page and type a question the way you would say it out loud:

| *what is the total revenue?*

Then ask **one question of your own** — for example revenue by month, or the number of customers.

| ☒ **Notice:** whether you believed the answer, and what you would do to check it.

12 • Re-run an earlier question

Open the query history and run one of your earlier questions again.

| ☒ **Notice:** anything different about how the answer comes back the second time.

13 • One more project (*optional — skip if you are short on time*)

Create a second project, and see whether the first project's data shows up in it.

Last step

Open the form and fill it in — mostly tick boxes, about 4 minutes:

<https://forms.cloud.microsoft/e/H0nvCdQ6Nm>

Please do it straight away, while it is fresh.

Thank you. This genuinely helps.

Any questions? Get in touch at any point, during this or afterwards — Yanfei Yu,
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